terms of the agreement, India was to station its troops in the Northern (Jaffna) and North-eastern (Trincomalee) provinces of Sri Lanka, to keep the warring factions at bay. This force, known as the Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF), began to deploy in Sri Lanka soon thereafter, with the operation being nicknamed Operation Pawan. The agreement was not received favourably in Sri Lanka, where it was seen as a bit of arm-twisting by India and a military intervention under the guise of a peace-keeping force. 54 Infantry Division from Secunderabad was the first to be inducted, followed by 72 Infantry Division from Gwalior, getting deployed in Northern (Jaffna) and Eastern (Trincomalee) provinces, respectively. Because of these developments, the unit's tenure at Binaguri was truncated and we were slotted to move to Sri Lanka in the latter half of 1988, under 72 Infantry Brigade of 36 Infantry Division. As soon as I came to know of this development, I rang up Col Ashok Kapur, volunteering to rejoin the paltan without completing the stipulated two-year tenure at the Centre. Col Kapur was to move out shortly as the military assistant (MA) to the General Officer Commanding-in-Chief (GOC-in-C) of Southern Command, Lt Gen AK Chatterjee.[1] He advised me that I should complete my tenure, since I had only about six months or so to go up to March 1989 and join in the normal course. However, he would sound out the incoming CO, Col NK Banerjee, who could take a fresh call.

Meanwhile, I was earmarked to attend the Junior Command (JC) course at the Army War College, Mhow. The JC course is not only an important career course but it also lays the foundation for the Defence Services Staff College (DSSC) course. While the JC course is mandatory for all officers, the DSSC one is through a stiff competitive exam. It was important to do well in the JC course, so I had taken a spot of leave to

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation